

more advanced. This move, needless to say, changed Microsoft's fortunes in later years.

Though the hardware for the IBM PC was “open,” the basic input/output system (BIOS) was proprietary. This was done to retain control of the architecture. However, companies like Compaq and Columbia Data Products did rewrite the “ROM-BIOS” of the IBM PC from scratch to produce their own versions of the PC that did not infringe on the patents and copyrights of the original. This led to an alternative market of PCs priced lower than the original IBM PC.

The IBM PC was the first sewing machine sized machine that was affordable for the masses. Its shape and size were so successful that it became the de facto form factor for PCs as we know them today.

1982

The Processor Wars Begin

February: The 286

Intel launched its 80286 series of processors in February, 1982. It was commonly referred to as “the 286”, and at its fastest speed, was almost twice as fast as its predecessors while retaining backward compatibility.

The 286 was first released at 6 MHz and was later scaled up to 25 MHz, though it was predominantly sold as a 16 MHz processor. It was widely used in the IBM PC and its clones for the next ten years. An estimated 15 million PCs with these processors were sold in the period spanning 1982 through 1989.

The 286 was the first processor designed specifically for multitasking operations, a concept that was gaining ground during this period. It was also the first to provide a “protected mode,” wherein multiple applications could compute independently in